

3 hip fixes for the aches you train around

If your knees grumble on the stairs or your lower back nags by the end of the day, the problem often isn't the knee or the back at all — it's the hips. Years of sitting leave the hips stiff and the muscles around them switched off, and the knee and lower back quietly end up doing jobs that were never theirs to do.

Here are three simple moves to start putting that right. No kit, nothing fancy, nothing you can't do on a bit of floor at home. Do them a few times a week and give them a fortnight before you judge them — this is about changing how the body moves, and that takes a little repetition.



Open the front of the hip

Kneeling hip flexor stretch

Sitting all day leaves the muscle at the front of your hip short and tight. Left like that, it quietly tips your pelvis forward and tugs on your lower back all day long — which is why so much back ache actually begins at the hip, not the spine.

START

Kneel on one knee with the other foot flat on the floor in front of you, like the bottom of a lunge. Sit tall — imagine a string lifting the crown of your head toward the ceiling. A cushion under the kneeling knee makes it kinder.

FOCUS

Gently brace your core, as if bracing for a light prod to the stomach, and tuck your tailbone under just slightly. This stops your lower back arching and “cheating” the stretch. You should feel it across the front of the rear hip — not in the back, and not in the front knee.

MOVEMENT

Keeping tall, ease your hips forward an inch or two until you feel a comfortable stretch at the front of the kneeling hip. Don't lunge deep — small is plenty. Hold there and breathe slowly, letting the muscle release a little more on each out-breath. Then switch sides.

DO Hold 20–30 seconds each side, 2–3 times. It should feel like a steady stretch, never a pinch.

The point: Give that muscle its length back and your pelvis settles where it belongs — less constant pull on the back, and far more room for the hip to actually do its job.

2

Wake the glutes up

Glute bridge

Your glutes are the engine of the hip — they're meant to power your steps, your stairs, and your standing up out of a chair, while protecting your back and knees. Sit on them for years, though, and they go quiet. When that happens, smaller muscles around the back and knees pick up the slack they were never built for, and that's when the aches creep in.

START

Lie on your back with your knees bent and your feet flat on the floor, roughly hip-width apart, heels a comfortable distance from your backside. Arms resting by your sides.

FOCUS

Before you move, squeeze your backside as if you're trying to hold a coin between your cheeks, and gently brace your core. The work should be felt in the glutes — not in your lower back or the backs of your thighs. If you feel it gripping in your back, you've gone too high.

MOVEMENT

Drive through your heels and push your hips up toward the ceiling until your body makes a straight line from shoulders to knees. Squeeze your glutes hard at the top and hold for two seconds, then lower slowly and with control — don't just flop down. That slow lower is half the exercise.

DO 10–12 reps, 2–3 rounds. Quality beats height every time.

The point: This switches the right muscle back on and teaches it to fire again. A glute that's doing its job is one that takes the strain off your knees and lower back and puts it where it was always meant to be.

3

Steady the hip sideways

Clamshell

On the side of your hip sits a muscle whose job is to keep your knee tracking straight when you walk, climb and balance. When it's weak, the knee quietly drifts inward under load — and that inward drift is one of the most common reasons knees start aching on stairs and hills.

START

Lie on your side with your hips stacked directly on top of one another and your knees bent to about 45°, feet together. Rest your head on your lower arm and use your top hand on the floor in front for balance.

FOCUS

Keep your hips genuinely stacked and still. The big temptation is to let your hips roll backward to open the knee further — don't. The movement happens only at the hip joint, and keeping still is what makes it work.

MOVEMENT

Keeping your feet touching, slowly open your top knee upward like a clamshell opening. Pause for a moment at the top where you feel the side of your hip working, then close slowly. Repeat. (Optional: once it feels easy, a light resistance band looped just above the knees makes it considerably harder.)

DO 10–12 each side, 2–3 rounds, slow and controlled throughout.

The point: A stronger, more switched-on side-hip keeps the knee lined up properly when you load it — and that's half the battle with stair and hill pain solved.

A word from me

These three won't fix everything — but they'll show you something worth knowing: most aches in a well-used body aren't actually where the pain is. They're upstream, in how the body moves and which muscles have gone quiet. Fix the cause and the symptom very often quiets down on its own.

That's the whole idea behind how I coach. If you want a programme built around your body — your injuries, your restrictions, the way you actually move and the things you want to get back to — that's exactly what I do, online, for people anywhere.

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